

This page recaps the "acting for the camera" tips we covered in class last night, plus a few we didn't touch on yet:

FRAMING

- It's essential for actors to know whether or not they're being filmed in a closeup, medium shot or wide shot, so they can calibrate their performances to the framing. If you're not sure of your framing, ask the camera operator about the parameters of the shot. (Film etiquette tip: Don't ask the director unless he/she is also operating the camera.)
- Calibrating your performance means making it larger or smaller according to the framing (how large you are in the shot). Just as performances need to become "smaller" and more internal when we shift from stage to film, performances "shrink" again (become more minimal) as we move from long (full body) shots (showing the whole figure) to closeups on the face.

To get the hang of this, remember that the camera is a surrogate (stand-in) for another person.

Long/full shot: imagine you're talking to a friend across the room from you. You may need to speak a little louder, be a little more decisive in order to make your emotions clear.

Medium shot: Your friend is three or four feet away from you. It takes less work to communicate. (This often feels like the most natural performance, to the actor.)

Closeup: Your friend (or enemy) is inches from your face. You don't have to raise your voice at all to be heard.

In closeups, tilting your head forward or to the side may move it out of frame. You can however TURN your head (pivot left and right).

MARKS

- Practice walking to your mark until you can hit it. Don't look down as you're walking. (The mark may be a piece of tape or a temporary line drawn with a washable marker on the floor.) If you have trouble hitting a

mark, move to your mark and look around to see two objects that line up visually. Then when you walk toward it, you'll know you've "arrived" when they line up.

- Tip: try walking backwards from your mark while saying (or thinking) a short phrase such as "walk to the mark," squaring up your feet, then walking forward while saying the same line. (Or you could use numbers instead of words, as was pointed out last night in class... whatever works.)
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DON'T LOOK AT THE CAMERA

- Never spike the camera. (Never look directly at the camera when you're being filmed, unless the director asks you to.) Scenes in feature movies have been ruined and had to be retaken because a single background extra spiked the camera. The movie's audience can always tell, and will always spot the actor doing so.
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DON'T CUT YOURSELF

- Never "cut" your own scene (end your scene or drop out of character without hearing "cut").

Even if you feel that you've made a mistake or flubbed a line, keep going until the director says "Cut." He or she may be able to use part of the take, or not care about the error.

OTHER GENERAL TIPS

- Try not to blink during closeups or extreme closeups, even if you have a long speech. If you need to blink, do so between sentences.
- If the actor you're talking to is not facing you straight-on, look at (make eye contact with) his or her nearest eye.
- Always be aware of the your scene partner's eye line. (If there's a stand-in for your scene partner, he or she should be the same height.)
- Stay in character for your scene partner even when you're off camera (if he or she is talking to or looking at you).
- Find your character's energy and stay in character during both rehearsals and takes.

- If you can't see the camera, it can't see you. When you're "facing" the camera but not looking directly toward it, i.e., holding a 3/4 front view, check to make sure that you should be able to see the camera with both eyes, not just one. (Close each eye separately to test.) If either of your eyes can't see it, turn your face slightly so that both can (unless requested otherwise by the director.)

- Your performance (emotional nuances) may change from take to take, but your gestures and actions should not. Practice actions (blocking) as if they were words, aiming for the same accuracy.

- You may be asked stand unnaturally (or embarrassingly) close to other actors in some shots... way closer than you would stand to anyone in real life. Generally speaking, as the camera moved from framing wide shots to closeups, the actors are asked to stand closer to each other.